

Moroccan cuisine is a delicious mix of many influences, from Amazigh and Andalusian to Mediterranean and African. **Rashmi Vasudeva** samples an array of dishes and is taken in by the contrasts on offer — meat with prunes, savoury and sweet pastilla, and refreshing mint tea

It is more than a little disconcerting when effusive travel-brochure declarations turn out to be true. Every time you read about Morocco, there's that sentence: a country of contrasts. At least in its cuisine, I discovered it certainly is. Meat arrives with prunes; a slow-cooked beef stew can taste fruity and spicy, with a hint of floral; desserts have orange blossoms adorning them; and, oh, figs and almonds appear when you least expect them, sometimes sitting pretty next to lemon zest in a meat dish. This is a cuisine that seems to have absorbed Morocco itself: Amazigh, Andalusian, Arab, Jewish, Mediterranean, and African influences all merge in a country that's always trying to do several things at once.

It took me a while to understand that this is not Moroccans being random. Moroccan food is a repository of all the people who have passed through this land. The Amazigh (the indigenous people of North Africa) influence runs deep; Arab traditions, as well as the cuisines of Muslim and Jewish communities, and influences from Spain and other Mediterranean countries, have all found their way into Moroccan kitchens.

Tagine experience
The first dish most visitors meet is, inevitably, the tagine. I had seen the familiar conical pot countless times, but watching one emerge from a kitchen with such ceremony is an experience by itself. The vessel is both cooking pot and serving dish, its distinctive lid

Sweet, spiced and Moroccan



Chicken tagine with assorted dried fruits and salads.



Fresh Moroccan pastilla.



Typical mint tea ritual.

designed to return condensed steam to the food. The result? Slow-cooked meat, be it beef or chicken, is never chewy or hard. Saturated with spice and sauces, it is meat that melts. The combinations are creative. You will find chicken paired with olives, with an occasional fig peeping out. Lamb may arrive alongside prunes and apricots or even vegetables. This renders nearly every dish a permutation of sweet and spice.



Beef stew in tagine.

Then there is the couscous, which is quite literally everywhere. An acquired taste at best, or so was my impression. That was because, before I visited Morocco, all I had seen of couscous was unappetising mounds in some fine-dining restaurants. Here, it is not only the national dish, but you also find Moroccans actually being affectionate towards it. While couscous is basically semolina rolled till fluffy

and steamed, it is the topping that matters: often a combination of vegetables, meat and dried fruits that are available aplenty in the country.

Time for a 'dessert'

In Fez, I got to savour the most startling sweet-savoury 'dessert' of them all: the pastilla. Get this: It looks like a pastry with a filling. Now, it has almond shavings on top (usually) and is essentially a pie with crisp, thin layers of pastry with a filling of, err... shredded chicken or shrimp (yes), sometimes fish, traditionally rabbit or pigeon meat. It is slow-cooked (yes, this too) with spices such as cinnamon, ginger and saffron, and the final flourish is the dusting of powdered sugar on top. Sounds improbable? But, weirdly enough, it makes sense. For you see, Fez was a town that several communities passed through, often in long caravans on their way to the Strait of Gibraltar. Recipes, cooking techniques and taste all were fused to produce something as curious as the pastilla.

Once you leave the urban splendour behind and drive towards the Sahara, the food gets earthier. The Amazigh influence becomes particularly visible, and the focus is on food that doesn't weigh your tummy down but gives you energy. Think dates, almonds, olives, and flatbreads. The Medfouna, for instance, is a stuffed flatbread packed with minced meat, herbs and spices. In the desert's sand and heat, food becomes both restoration and an experience. You end up eating light, but you also pay it more obeisance.

Whisky, err...tea

Moroccans have a standard running joke: that they consume 'whisky' at all times of the day. This 'whisky' is, of course, the famous Moroccan mint tea. The story goes that the greater the height from which it is poured, the greater the love you will receive. From whom, I asked, and one particularly genial Moroccan told me it could be from the one you have always loved, the one who has always loved you, the universe, or God... take your pick. Tea, sugar (Moroccans get mildly offended if you take your mint tea without sugar), and mint may be simple ingredients, but Moroccan mint tea is not really about the tea itself. It is about the country's culture of hospitality: tea is an excuse to welcome you, chat with you, and its pouring is a little performance designed to convince you to stay. (The writer was in Morocco recently at the invitation of the Moroccan National Tourist Office.)

Food for comfort

RANJINI RAO

My daughter had caught a stomach bug for a few days, and lost her appetite. Once the fever had let up, she was



craving something slightly savoury and spicy to revive her palate. "Rasam, rice and potatoes on the side," she said, "that's comfort food for me, especially when I'm under the weather."



THE GREEN THEORY

Having been through an array of comfort food choices during her growing up years, this came as a pleasant surprise to me. No more pasta with pink sauce, I thought to myself, or PB&Js (peanut butter and jam/jelly sandwiches). She added rajma-chawal with pickled onions and rice with thick, yellow dal, mixed with ghee to the list. While all of these reflect the multicuisine culture in my kitchen, it got me thinking about how traditions affect our yearning for comfort food. My childhood pivoted around food from Malnad and Kolar, where my maternal and paternal grandparents were from, respectively: think pickles and kadubus. This brought back something I'd read earlier: food and nutrition expert Annie Hauck-Lawson's description of "food voice," where food is a "channel for the expression of meaning." I grew up being encouraged to hear food as a voice which has helped me recognise subtler details in my food, its dialects and inflections, and the idea of personal identity that stems from it.

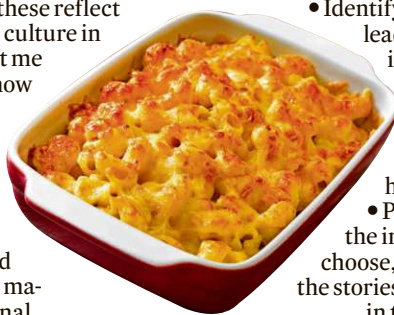
My travels and inter-cultural marriage are two factors that decreed the kind of cook I'd become, and the culture of my kitchen. My daughter grew up on a diet of delicacies from this mixed bag, cov-

ering everything from rasam-rice to aloo-sheddho-bhaat, with mac-and-cheese, deep dish pizzas and pavlovas and golden kiwi topped with hokey pokey ice cream.

One common thread in all this has always been: mindful eating. I've always encouraged her to forge a deeper connection with the food she's eating and its impact on the planet. This idea fits into the broader narrative of holistic wellness today. Like anthropologist Sidney Mintz said, "For us humans eating is never a 'purely biological' activity. The foods eaten have histories associated with the pasts of those who eat them; the techniques employed to find, process, prepare, serve, and consume the foods are all culturally variable, with histories of their own."

Tips to stay mindful

- Staying attuned to your hunger signals and knowing when you're satisfied can guide you towards making healthier choices, especially better portion control.
- Identifying triggers that lead to stress eating is important. Getting a grip on your eating patterns will help you build healthier habits.
- Pay attention to the ingredients you choose, their origin, the stories linked to them in the farmer community and in socio-cultural contexts. This helps



Mac and cheese is a popular comfort food.

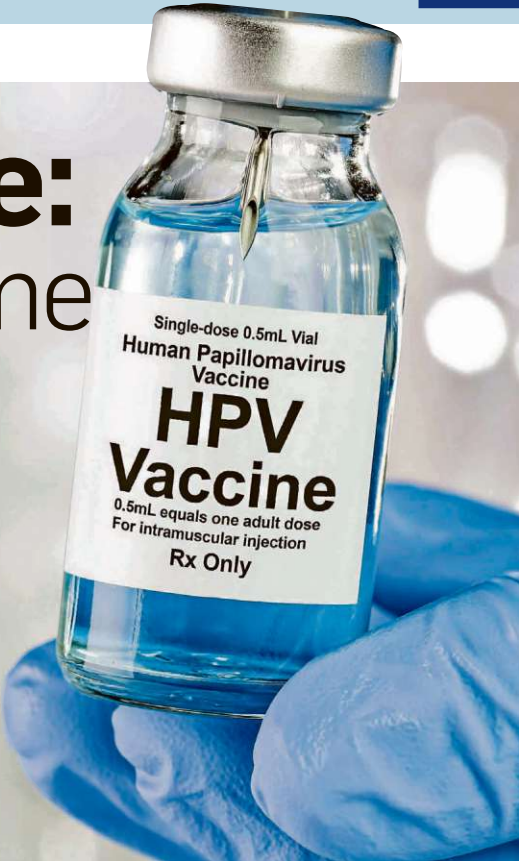
you acknowledge the journey of the ingredients. Food is not just nourishment; your mood dictates what and how you eat, and the reverse is true as well. Visit your nearest market, understand local produce and the traditional ways in which they are cooked.

(Ranjini is a communications professor, author, and podcaster, straddling many other worlds, in Bengaluru. She's passionate about urban farming and sustainable living, and can mostly be found cooking and baking in her little kitchen, where, surrounded by heirloom coffee kettles and mismatched tea cups, she finds her chi.)

Wellness

Missed dose: It's catch-up time

The government's free HPV vaccination programme is aimed at girls aged 14. From ages 15 to 26, women may have to opt for a catch-up vaccination privately, while navigating misconceptions and cost barriers, writes **Subhashini Ramasamy**



ed, the virus itself went unaddressed. "When I tested positive again, the doctor at the time was surprised that I hadn't taken the vaccine already," she says.

Dr Shweta explains, "If a patient carries one strain (of the virus) today, the vaccine protects her against the other strains."

More awareness, uneven uptake
At Gleneagles BGS Hospital, Bengaluru, 18 to 20 HPV vaccine doses have been administered to women aged between 18 and 26 over the last year. "The decision seems to come from having greater awareness about cervical cancer and the role of HPV vaccination in prevention. Changes in sexual activity also prompt women to consider vaccination," notes senior consultant — obstetrician and gynaecologist Dr Sowmya K N.

At Fortis Hospital Mohali, there has been an increase in vaccination among women in their 20s. "In 2023, we dispersed 67 HPV vaccine doses, while in 2025, that number crossed 250," notes Dr Shweta.

On the other hand, only 10-12 patients aged between 20 and 35 have taken the vaccine at Marengo Asia Hospitals, Gurugram, over the last six months. "Although young women are proactively enquiring about it, the uptake is still low," says Dr Pallavi.

Cost seems to be another barrier. Depending on the brand, the full course can cost between Rs 5,000 and Rs 33,000. Dr Pallavi suggests looking at the vaccine as a "one-time investment," to overcome the financial and emotional burden that comes with cervical cancer treatment.

From a policy standpoint
"India's programme currently relies on imported vaccines as the locally manufactured version by Serum Institute has not been cleared for single dose usage yet," says Dr Ravi Mehrotra, founder, Centre for Health Innovation and Policy, Noida. At this stage, Dr Ravi believes that it is suitable to prioritise the aging out group that would benefit most. "Once the Indian vaccine gets approved, we should eventually have enough doses to cover for all girls aged 9 to 14," he adds.

Dr Abhishek Shankar, assistant professor of radiation oncology at AIIMS, Delhi, believes that vaccination, screening, and treatment should work in tandem for reduction in cervical cancer rates. "In 2022, cervical cancer incidence in India was around 1.27 lakh. But in 2024, it fell to 79,000," he says, adding, "No woman should die from a cancer that is preventable." (*Names changed to protect identity.)

early. A nonavalent vaccine, which protects against nine strains of HPV, offers the broadest coverage, while a bivalent vaccine protects against two high-risk strains. The quadrivalent vaccine, used in the government drive, covers four strains.

Dr Shweta notes that cervical cancer usually shows up in a woman's 40s or 50s, which means that catch-up vaccines can offer protection before they enter their 30s, "when most pre-cancerous changes appear."

Myths and misses

For Parul's* mother, the primary concern is infertility. "She thinks it is safe for me to take the vaccine only after I've had kids," 25-year-old Parul says.

Dr Pallavi Vasal, director and head, gynaecology and obstetrics, Marengo Asia Hospitals, Gurugram, says there is no evidence that the vaccine affects fertility, pregnancy, or hormonal health. She adds that catch-up vaccination offers benefits because many have not yet been exposed to all the high-risk HPV strains covered by the vaccine. "The benefit post 26 may be lower due to a higher likelihood of prior HPV exposure," she notes.

Karishma*, 30, first tested positive for HPV in 2021, and again last year. "I developed warts initially, and the doctors advised me to get them removed," says the Delhi-based professional. Although the genital warts were treat-

In February, the government launched its free vaccine programme for girls aged 14, targeting 1.2 crore vaccinations annually, with over 52 lakh vaccinated as of July 15. But from age 15, women have to seek catch-up vaccination privately, navigating misconceptions and cost barriers.

Is there still a chance?

For women who learn about the vaccine, the first question that comes up is if they have missed the chance. The WHO and the Federation of Obstetric and Gynaecological Societies of India (FOGSI) recommend catch-up vaccination up to age 26. "Though the HPV vaccine is approved for use up to age 45, the catch-up vaccine is for those aged 15 to 26 years," says Dr Shweta Tahlan, senior consultant, gynae-onco surgery, Fortis Hospital, Mohali.

The vaccine was presented to the parents of Pooja V (21) in a skewed manner — making it seem like it was only necessary when she would be of 'marriageable age'. Many*, from Bengaluru, has not gotten the vaccine yet because she thought she had passed the appropriate age (of 14). "My doctor said it would not work anymore," the 22-year-old shares.

The absence of sexual activity is not the only reason why vaccine efficacy is highest among 9-14-year-olds. The antibody response to the vaccine is robust at a young age, which is why most vaccines work best when given

MYTHBUSTER

MICROPLASTICS: Are alarm bells ringing?

DR S P SHARMA

Many parents microwave sippy cups fresh out of a hot wash, and let babies chew on plastic toys without a second thought. These habits feel ordinary but research suggests they deserve a closer look.

Microplastics have moved from oceans into the human body. Scientists have detected them in placental tissue, cord blood, breast milk, and infant stool. Children absorb microplastics at higher rates than adults, relative to body weight because they eat more, breathe more, and explore the world 'mouth-first'. Their organs are still forming, their gut lining is thin, and their detox pathways are still maturing.

Laboratory and animal studies link microplastic exposure to oxidative stress, gut microbiome disruption, and interference with hormone signalling. Hospitals in China have detected microplastic particles in the lungs of young children, with links to allergic rhinitis. These findings are from reputable, peer reviewed journals through 2025 and 2026. A 2025 study published in Eco-Environment & Health, the first of its kind to link paediatric microplastic exposure with allergic rhinitis, says this connection was largely seen in children aged six or below.

No direct causation

However, most data available today show association, not direct causation. Studies haven't yet directly proven that a certain level of exposure in childhood will lead to a certain disease decades later and this needs long-term studies which are ongoing. While the risk is sometimes dismissed by industry voices as speculative, it is presented as a settled fact by some campaigns. The evidence

currently supports a middle path, one with enough signal to justify reducing exposure, while the full picture is yet to emerge.

Prenatal and infant exposure occur during critical windows of organ development, when even minor disruptions can echo for years. Given how slowly definitive proof can accumulate, it helps to take into account current exposure levels and stay cautious. Simple choices at home can go a long way towards damage control.

Cutting daily exposure

- Use glass or ceramic containers for microwaving food or milk instead of plastic.



- Rinse baby bottles with cold water before and after sterilising, because hot water increases particle release.
 - Prepare baby formula with room-temperature water.
 - Serve hot beverages or oily foods in glass or steel containers instead of plastic.
 - Choose loose produce over plastic-wrapped items.
 - Keep your homes well-ventilated. Vacuum and dust surfaces regularly, because household dust carries a significant, often overlooked share of daily exposure.
- (The author is a senior consultant — paediatrics at a Noida hospital.)
- (Mythbuster is a column that picks up a popular wellness belief and examines if it is true, false, or maybe lies somewhere in between.)**

QUICK FACTS

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